Fly Away Home

By Eve Bunting

CHILD: *(sings)* * I never dreamed I'd ever be,

Without a home to comfort me

'Til a friend of mine this very Spring

Lost his whole house and everything.

INTRODUCTION

*There is a common misconception that homelessness is an issue that only pertains to single men and women, but **according to the National Alliance to End Homelessness, almost 60,000 families are homeless on a given night in the United States.*

*Homelessness is a devastating experience for families. It disrupts every aspect of their lives, damaging their physical and emotional health and interfering with children's education and development. *** According to the Bassuk Center: 1 in 30 children in the US experience homelessness – That's 2.5 million children! This is Andrew's story . . .*

Fly Away Home by Eve Bunting

CHILD: My dad and I live in an airport. That's because we don't have a home and the airport is better than the streets. We are careful not to get caught. *(beat)* Mr. Slocum and Mr. Vail were caught last night.

MR. SLOCUM: *(singing)* Ten green bottles, hanging on the wall . . .

CHILD: They were as loud as two moose bellowing. Dad said they broke the first rule of living here.

DAD: ***Don't get noticed.***

CHILD: Dad and I try not to get noticed. We stay among the crowds. We change airlines.

DAD: Delta, TWA, Northwest, we love them all.

CHILD: He and I wear blue jeans and blue T-shirts and blue jackets. We each have a blue zippered bag with a change of blue clothes. Not to be noticed is to look like nobody at all. Once we saw a woman pushing a metal cart full of stuff. She wore a long dirty coat and she lay down across a row of seats in front of Continental Gate 6. The cart, the dirty coat, the lying down were all noticeable. Security Moved her out real fast. Dad and I sleep sitting up. We use different airport areas. (to Dad) Where are we tonight?

DAD: *(checking his notebook)* Alaska Air. Over in the other terminal.

CHILD: That's OK. We like to walk. We know some of the

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

airport regulars by name and by sight. There's Idaho Joe and Annie Frannie and Mars Man. But we don't sit together.

DAD: Sitting together will get you noticed faster than anything.

CHILD: Everything in the airport is on the move -- passengers, pilots, flight attendants, cleaners with their brooms. Jets roar in, close to the windows. Other jets roar out. Luggage bounces down chutes, escalators glide up and down, disappearing under floors. Everyone's going somewhere except Dad and me. We stay.

Once a little brown bird got into the main terminal and couldn't get out. It fluttered in the high, hollow spaces. It threw itself at the glass, fell panting on the floor, flew to a tall metal girder, and perched there exhausted. *(to bird)* Don't stop trying. Don't! You can get out!

(to audience) For days the bird flew around, dragging one wing. And then it found the instant when a sliding door was open and slipped through. I watched it rise. Its wing seemed OK. *(whispering to bird)* Fly bird. Fly away home! *(to audience)* Though I couldn't hear it, I knew it

4NG Fanatics

was singing. Nothing made me as happy as that bird.

The airport's busy and noisy even at night. Dad and I sleep anyway. When it gets quiet, between two and four a.m., we wake up.

DAD: Dead time. Almost no flights coming in or going out.

CHILD: At dead time there aren't many people around, so we're extra careful. In the mornings Dad and I wash up in one of the bathrooms, and he shaves. The bathrooms are crowded, no matter how early. And that's the way we like it. *(beat)* Strangers talk to strangers . . .

STRANGER 1: Where did you get in from?

STRANGER 2: Three hours our flight was delayed. Ma, am I bushed!

CHILD: Dad and **I,** we don't talk to anyone. We buy doughnuts and milk for breakfast at one of the cafeterias, standing in line with our red trays. Sometimes Dad gets me a carton of juice.

On the weekends Dad takes the bus to work. He's a janitor in an office in the city. The bus fare's a dollar each way. On those days Mrs. Medina looks out for me. The Medinas live in the airport too - Grandma, Mrs. Medina

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

and Denny, who's my friend. He and I collect rented luggage carts that people have left outside and return them for fifty cents each. If the crowds are big and safe, we offer to carry bags.

(to traveler) Get this one for you, lady? It looks heavy. *(to another traveler)* Can I call you a cab?

Denny's real good at calling cabs. That's because he's seven already. Sometimes passengers don't tip. Then Denny whispers, ***stingy***! But he doesn't whisper too loud. The Medinas understand that it's dangerous to be noticed.

When Dad comes home from work, he buys hamburgers for us and the Medinas. That's to pay them for watching out for me. If Denny and I've had a good day, we treat for pie. But I've stopped doing that. I save my money in my shoe.

(to Dad) Will we ever have our apartment again? *(to audience)* I'd like it to be the way it was before Mom died.

DAD: Maybe we will. If I can find more work. If we can save some money. *(tousling the child's hair)* It's nice right here, though, isn't it? It's warm. It's safe. And the price is right.

4NG Fanatics

CHILD: But I know he's trying all the tme to find us a place. He takes newspapers from the trash baskets and makes pencil circles around letters and numbers. Then he goes to the phones. When he comes back he looks sad. Sad and angry. I know he's been calling about an apartment. I know the rents are too high for us.

(to Dad) I'm saving money, too! *(lifts one foot and points to shoe)*

DAD: *(smiling)* Atta boy!

DENNY: If we get a place, you and your dad can come live with us.

CHILD: And we get a place, you and your mom and your grandma can come live with us.

DENNY: Yeah!

CHILD: *(to audience)* We shake on it. That's going to be so great! After next summer, Dad says, I have to start school. *(to Dad)* How?

DAD: I don't know. But it's important. We'll work it out.

CHILD: Denny's momsays he can wait for a while. But Dad

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

says I can't wait. *(long beat)* Sometimes I watch people meeting people.

STRANGER 1: We missed you.

STRANGER 2: It's so good to be home.

CHILD: Sometimes I get mad, and I want to run at them and push them and shout.

(shouting) Why do you have homes when we don't? What makes you so special?

(to audience) That would get us noticed, all right. Sometimes I just want to cry. *(long beat)* I think Dad and I will be here forever. *(beat)* Then I remember the bird. *(whispering to himself)* Don't stop trying. Don't! You can get out!

It took a while, but a door opened. And when the bird left, when it flew free, I know it was singing

(sings) * I never dreamed I'd ever be,
Without a home to comfort me
'Til a friend of mine this very Spring
Lost his whole house and everything.
So now I know that life is strange,
That all is luck and luck can change,

4NG Fanatics

And don't forget, it's sad but true,
The next time around it could be you . . .

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Eve Bunting
ISBN: 978-0395664155
Publisher: Clarion Books
Date (Month/Year): Mar 1993

AWARD HISTORY

2022 National Qualifier – MS

* *Song excerpt from "Homelessness" by Lou and Lou Berryman from their CD Some Days*

Lyrics: *http://www.protestsonglyrics.net/Tenants_Housing_Homeless_Songs/Homelessness.phtml*

Music: *https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=6rjYGnJRSio*

Source information for introduction statistics and additional information on the issues

** ***National Alliance to End Homelessness*** ***https://endhomelessness.org/homelessness-in-america/homelessness-statistics/state-of-homelessness/***

*** ***The Bassuk Center statistics as found at*** **https://schoolonwheels.org/homelessness-in-america/**

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY